

US Communications Infrastructure

CoreWeave, Inc.

Rating

Underperform

Price Target

 CRWV

74.00 USD



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Quick Take: CoreWeave - thoughts from CRWV's Fully Connected conference...a maybe-better strategy, but a long way to go

CRWV is hosting their first [Fully Connected](#) conference in San Francisco this week, predominantly aimed at AI engineers, platform engineers, CTOs, etc. It's a clear marketing play, attempting to build a network and ecosystem around their platform - akin to an AWS re:Invent, Google Cloud Next, or Nvidia GTC. This coincides with CRWV's "[we're no longer a neocloud](#)" messaging this morning and the announcement of a new set of developer tools called CoreWeave Forge.

It's no secret that [we're not the biggest fans of CoreWeave's business model](#) - a GPU rental business in an increasingly competitive market. Of their existing potential customer bases: **hyperscalers** are increasingly head-on competitors and/or balancing their own internal capacity with self-builds and colo, the **major labs** are likely to have a mix of self-builds, colo, and better-priced cloud from the hyperscalers, and **enterprises** will have strong incentive to buy from their traditional cloud provider. We believe the hyperscalers win the market. But that leaves CRWV in a bit of a strategic pickle...

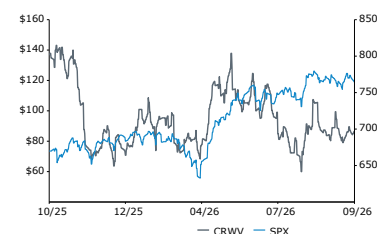
So what would we do in their shoes? **Pivot.** Move up the stack. Find a way to carve off a portion of that future GPU cloud market. Identify a group of enterprises that have strong reasons to use an external vendor and lock them in with some kind of moat. Do your absolute best to capture enough of the right AI startups that some of them will succeed, scale, remain loyal, and drive massive revenue growth. Create high-margin, obviously scalable products that can juice infrastructure returns and seed ongoing investment. Maintain tight relationships with ecosystem leaders who can supplement your credibility with this customer base.

Fully Connected is CRWV trying to do just that. It's an archetypical SF tech conference, complete with Battle Bots, Pitbull, a lot of branded t-shirts, and the crowd you'd expect. Will it actually work? We don't really think so. Even if you believe in the Forge / Managed Inference / Full Stack vision (we're skeptical, details below), this is effectively a startup chained to a big GPUaaS business with a \$100B+ backlog's worth of mostly-locked-in economics. **No change to our rating, but at least something new to try.**

Close Date	30 Sep 2026			
CRWV Close Price (USD)	87.12			
Price Target (USD)	74.00			
Upside/(Downside)	(15)%			
52-Week Range	153.20/60.55			
SPX	7,651.54			
FYE	Dec			
Div Yield	NA			
Market Cap (USD) (M)	48,689			
EV (USD) (M)	94,758			
Performance	YTD	1M	6M	12M
Absolute (%)	21.7	2.6	12.5	(36.3)
SPX (%)	11.8	(0.4)	17.2	14.4
Relative (%)	9.9	3.1	(4.7)	(50.7)

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

Price Performance, 1YR



Adjusted EPS	F25A	F26E	F27E	Financials	F25A	F26E	F27E	CAGR	Valuation Metrics	25A	26E	27E
CRWV (USD)	(1.20)	(4.56)	(4.77)	Revenues (M)	5,131	12,622	23,552	114.2%	EV/EBIT (x)	N/M	302	38.2
				EBITDA (M)	2,442	6,826	14,974	147.6%	Adjusted P/E (x)	(72.8)	(19.1)	(18.3)

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

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WE DIDN'T LEARN A TON ABOUT THE CORE BUSINESS DURING TODAY'S SESSIONS AND CONVERSATIONS. ALMOST EVERYTHING WAS A REITERATION FROM 2Q EARNINGS:

- **CRWV continues to mark 2Q as an inflection point for margins**, citing price appreciation, market dynamics, and scale as contributing factors.
- Reiterated **active power at 1.5GW, contracted power at 4.2GW and 51 buildings**, all scaling.
- The company **re-articulated the longevity of GPUs**, particularly focusing on demand for both A100s and H200s from enterprises using/developing smaller or proprietary models.
- Management continues to point out how aggressively **demand outstrips supply**, how customers are accepting **price increases on new contracts**, and the need for **more short-term capacity**.
- Lots of **customer logos flashed**, across a range of industries, but **not yet any clear metrics** on new customer additions, product counts, managed inference revenue, etc. We know everything outside of the named deals is still relatively small.
- **Today there was zero discussion of the debt load or cost of capital**, though that continues to be a [major concern](#) for us.

WITH THAT, WE'LL FOCUS ON THE NEW, EXCITING ANNOUNCEMENT (THOUGH WE DON'T EXPECT IT TO SHOW UP MEANINGFULLY IN THE NUMBERS FOR QUITE SOME TIME)

[CoreWeave Forge](#) combines CoreWeave's Weights & Biases acquisition, OpenPipe post-training capabilities, Marimo notebooks, and CRWV services around a recurring process (what they're calling the AI Loop). Their goal is to own more of the work surrounding GPU consumption, not just supply the GPUs. Importantly, the product is mostly **cloud-neutral** (apart from the managed inference and post-training) **and likely better suited to an Open/Open-Weight Ecosystem**. In theory this could act as a hedge for CRWV's major lab contracts, though that assumes the business could get to massive scale (possible, but requires a lot of belief at this stage).

The consolidated Forge solution is aimed at enterprises, particularly AI-native start-ups, with some larger company traction thus far (Canva, MasterClass both named). The toolset functions as an acquisition vehicle that will hopefully be sticky on their own and eventually lead to more infrastructure-linked services. All of this is to be supported with a growing partner ecosystem, with the goal of making Forge a one-stop shop for AI development needs.

Management did concede that most of the capabilities are available via either other providers or open source alternatives, but that the CoreWeave differentiation comes from the integration. That can be a valid strategy - users absolutely appreciate a more seamless experience, particularly when the tools are disparate and require handoffs. But whether that is long-term durable is a bigger question.

OUR PRELIMINARY READ ON FORGE'S DIFFERENTIATION AND LONGEVITY

Forge was only announced today, so give us some time for a detailed competitive comparison, but our preliminary read is that it may be hard to create a true moat here. Just like for GPUaaS, hyperscalers are likely the best positioned to offer a full stack given their traditional cloud offerings and their broad enterprise bases. CoreWeave would push back on that, saying that they're leapfrogging the hyperscalers by being AI-native (the same way we used to talk about being "built in the cloud"), **but we don't like to bet against gorilla-sized incumbents when enterprises, AI-native or not, are still going to need significant traditional cloud capacity**.

Assuming CRWV is the only one with a fully-integrated AI loop solution today, **the hyperscale competitors are definitely not starting from zero**. AWS already documents training, tracking, serving and agent observability; Google connects evaluation with failure analysis and optimization; LangSmith connects production traces with datasets, diagnosis and proposed fixes and has at least some integration with the hyperscalers. That does not prove equivalent integration to CRWV, but it does mean that

integration could be replicable.

The best customers for this product are likely **specialized, AI-native companies with technically capable enterprise teams and repeatable workloads**. In other words, they need to justify model customization and operating complexity. Model distillation would broaden that audience if inference bills eventually balloon and smaller, more specialized models become more attractive. It doesn't require full adoption of open models, but it does require enough valuable tasks that rely on customization.

A standalone Forge product is likely **most valuable and stickiest when multi-cloud is the dominant IT strategy** or when CRWV is the infrastructure provider of choice. As we believe the latter may be challenging, we have to rely on the former...the challenge is that the AI-native startups most likely to adopt Forge today are often the least likely to run true multi-cloud architectures. In our experience, small companies (and start-ups) tend to stick with a single cloud. Multi-cloud is extremely prevalent in larger enterprises, where redundancy and supplier concentration are bigger concerns, but, for the most part, that's not the customer base under consideration at this stage.

There are lots of ways this could make financial sense without CRWV becoming a standalone software giant. Forge could eventually lower acquisition costs for new infrastructure customers, increase demand for eventual spot capacity (once GPUs roll off contract and CRWV actually has some capacity they can sell), improve margins or infrastructure returns, etc. But CoreWeave is at the very beginning of this journey. **Given our feelings about the core business and the relative scale, we would need to see real evidence of financial outcomes before becoming more constructive on the name.**

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

We are Underperform on CRWV with a price target of \$74. CRWV benefits from supply constraint in the data center market, which undoubtedly continues to exist today; however, as capacity eases, which we anticipate, this company will be among the first and hardest hit. We value the company on a 25.5x EV/EBIT basis.

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

			30 Sep 2026		TTM	Adjusted EPS				EV/EBIT (x)		
Ticker	Rating	Cur	Closing Price	Price Target	Rel. Perf.	Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
CRWV (CoreWeave)	U	USD	87.12	74.00	(50.7)%	USD	(1.20)	(4.56)	(4.77)	N/M	302	38.2
SPX			7,651.54									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

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VALUATION METHODOLOGY**CoreWeave, Inc.**

We value CRWV on a forward EV/Adjusted EBIT multiple. Our \$74 price target is based on an Enterprise Value calculated as 25.5x NTM+1 Adj. Operating Income of \$5.2B.

RISKS**CoreWeave, Inc.**

The main upside risks to our price target/Underperform rating on CRWV are 1) Delays in hyperscaler built capacity coming online may maintain CRWV value proposition, 2) Development of CRWV's specialized software platform which maintains demand for CRWV operated data centers, and 3) Continued shortage in power supply to power data centers may sustain CRWV's pricing power

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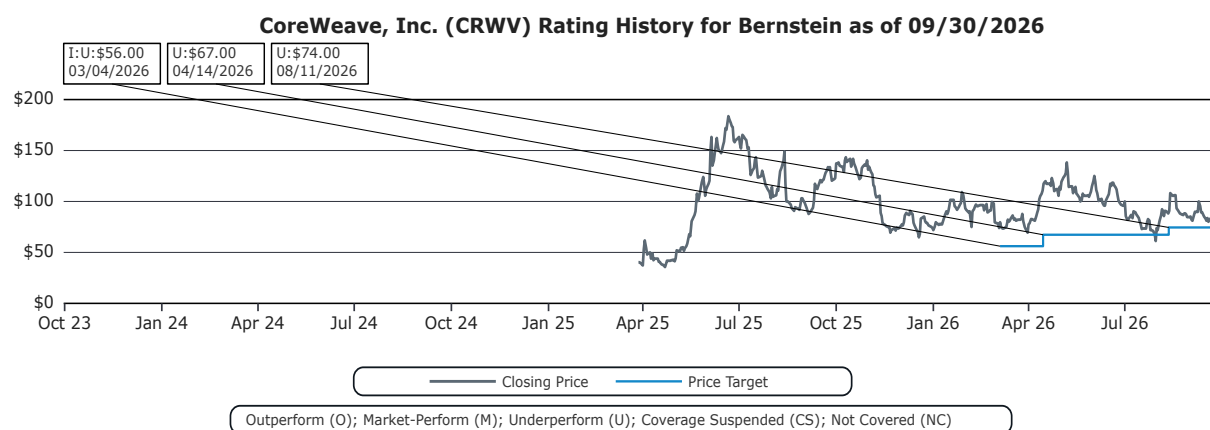
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Market-Perform (Bernstein Brand) Neutral (Autonomous Brand)	HOLD	35.6%	16.1%
Underperform	SELL	12.1%	13.6%

* These figures represent the percentage of companies within each equity rating category for which affiliates of Bernstein have provided investment banking services within the previous 12 months.
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